

“September Third”

I have been searching for the witness for two weeks.

At dawn, a hiker saw a young girl's body left in the woods. Strangled, battered, and personal items missing. The case had been all over town. Everyone kept saying the same things. Poor Sophie. Such a waste. She was such a good girl. Housewives all gather by their yards to gossip. People love to talk when they're frightened. They tell you more than what you asked, sometimes they tell you things they shouldn't. They point fingers, and eventually, someone slips. And I found the face of the repeating name everyone spoke, her best friend. Finding people is easy when silence is rare.

Her hair was unbrushed, eyes bloodshot, and she kept fiddling with the hem of her sleeve. I guided her to the booth against the wall of the diner. People feel safer where they can see the entrance. The coffee had grown cold when she finally spoke. A few days before the murder, they had gotten into a fight. Explains why I didn't see her name in Sophie's text messages. She was doing it again, fiddling with the hem of her sleeve as she recounted how Sophie had planned to meet someone in the woods. She didn't hide anything, she answered everything she knew. Including a boy Sophie had recently become close to. Grief has a way of sounding like guilt.

I let her finish her coffee and tipped the waiter before I left. Time was running, and I wanted to make sure I could speak to the boy before anyone else did. The more time passes, the more a witness can forget and change the story. Just like how the newspapers described Sophie's strangulation. Where a cord became a rope. A meeting became a runaway. Before long, people remember what they're told, not what happened.

Outside the neighbourhood, a group of guys in red varsity jackets loitered near the entrance. What's unique about fraternities is that they have each other's backs, so they didn't immediately agree to take me to my lead. But, when I murmured to their ears that the boy was a suspect to the murder of Sophie, they backed down quickly. When faced with justice, people are easily swayed. I like that. Makes things easier.

The house they led me to had its windows shut and curtains closed. The trash outside hadn't been moved in days. He was hiding. I knocked on the door, once, twice. I knew he was listening behind the door. He was afraid. I spoke first, soft and unaccusing. I was there to know what happened, and that his answers could help Sophie. The door opened to that. I walked in.

His voice was raised, bursting out in unintelligible sentences, his nails bitten to the quick. He remembered more than I hoped. I smiled, and squeezed his shoulder, my thumb rubbing circles. He felt cold, like the rain on that day.

“There you are.”

I found the loose end.